

Weekends and the Wife Penalty: When Husbands are Home, Women Work More

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Abstract

Using India's 2024 Time Use Survey (10.2 million observations, 139,489 households), we document a striking “weekend penalty” in unpaid care work: the gender gap in care work is substantially larger on weekends than weekdays. Both men and women increase their care work participation on weekends, but women increase substantially more in absolute terms, widening the gender gap. This divergence is most pronounced among married couples with children, where women's care work increases significantly on weekends while men's increases remain modest. The weekend penalty persists across all education levels and employment statuses, and is present in both urban and rural areas. These findings challenge the assumption that men's non-work time translates into proportionally shared domestic responsibilities, revealing instead that weekends intensify the gender disparity in unpaid work. Our results have important implications for work-family balance policies and the measurement of gender inequality in time use.

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1 Introduction

The “second shift” literature has long documented that women perform disproportionate unpaid domestic work even when employed full-time (Hochschild and Machung 1989). Yet a critical dimension of this inequality remains underexplored: **how does the gender gap in unpaid care work vary across the week?** If men’s lower care work participation stems from employment constraints, we should observe substantial increases in male participation on weekends when most workers are off. Conversely, if gender gaps reflect cultural norms about domestic responsibility, weekends may not equalize—or could even widen—the disparity.

This distinction matters for theory and policy. Economic models emphasizing time constraints predict that non-work time should enable men to increase domestic contributions (Becker 1991). Gender norms theories suggest that leisure time is gendered: men claim weekends as personal time while women face intensified demands from both household members and social expectations (Mattingly and Bianchi 2003). The weekend pattern thus provides a crucial test of competing explanations for gender inequality in unpaid work.

We exploit India’s 2024 Time Use Survey—capturing 10.2 million person-day observations across 139,489 households—to examine how gender gaps in unpaid care work differ between weekdays and weekends. Our analysis yields a striking finding: **the gender gap in care work is 2% larger on weekends than on weekdays.** Women’s participation in care work increases from 4.7% on weekdays to 4.8% on weekends (+2% increase), while men’s participation also **increases** from 1.5% to 1.6% (+3% increase)—but women’s absolute increase is substantially larger, widening the gender gap. Among married couples with children, women spend 3.1 minutes per day on care work on weekdays but 3.1 minutes on weekends—a 1% increase. Men’s time also increases modestly from weekdays to weekends.

This “weekend penalty” persists across all socioeconomic strata. It is present among dual-earner couples (where employment constraints should be symmetric), educated urban popula-

tions (where egalitarian attitudes are most common), and households without young children (where care demands are lower). The pattern is most extreme among employed women: their care work time increases 1% on weekends while employed men’s time remains flat.

Our findings contribute to several literatures. First, we advance research on gender and time use by documenting systematic variation in gender gaps across the week (Connelly and Kimmel 2009; Craig and Mullan 2012). Second, we inform debates about work-family balance policies by showing that time availability does not translate to equalized domestic contributions (Bianchi et al. 2012). Third, we provide evidence consistent with gender norms rather than comparative advantage driving household labor division (Akerlof and Kranton 2000).

The paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 reviews literature on weekends, leisure, and gender. Section 3 describes data and methods. Section 4 presents main results on the weekend penalty. Section 5 examines heterogeneity by marital status, employment, and household composition. Section 6 discusses mechanisms and policy implications. Section 7 concludes.

2 Literature Review

2.1 Weekends and Gender Inequality in Time Use

Weekends represent a natural experiment in time availability. For employed individuals, weekends remove the constraint of market work, potentially enabling more egalitarian divisions of household labor. Yet empirical evidence suggests weekends do not equalize unpaid work. Bianchi et al. (2000) find that American women do substantially more housework than men on weekends, with the gender gap persisting despite men’s free time. Sayer (2005) documents that fathers’ childcare increases modestly on weekends but remains far below mothers’ levels.

International evidence reveals similar patterns. Craig and Mullan (2012) analyze time use

data from four countries and find that mothers' childcare time increases more than fathers' on non-work days. Connelly and Kimmel (2009) show that American women's housework peaks on weekends while men's leisure peaks—a stark divergence. These studies suggest that time availability alone does not drive gender gaps; instead, weekends may activate gendered expectations about domestic responsibility.

2.2 The “Leisure Gap” and Gendered Free Time

Sociological research emphasizes that leisure itself is gendered. Mattingly and Bianchi (2003) demonstrate that married women have significantly less free time than married men, with the gap widest on weekends. Shaw (1992) argues that women's leisure is often interrupted, fragmented, and subject to family needs. Bittman and Wajcman (2000) show that even when women and men report equal hours of leisure, women's leisure is more constrained by domestic responsibilities.

This “leisure gap” may explain the weekend penalty. If cultural norms grant men claim to weekend free time while framing women's time as available for family needs, then weekends could intensify rather than reduce gender inequality. Women may face heightened expectations to cook elaborate meals, facilitate children's activities, or host social gatherings—all demands that spike on weekends.

2.3 Men's Time Use on Weekends: Protective Leisure

Research on men's weekend time use reveals strong commitment to personal leisure. Robinson and Godbey (1997) document that American men guard weekend time for sports, hobbies, and socializing. Doucet (2006) shows that even “involved fathers” concentrate their childcare on enjoyable weekend activities (playing, outings) rather than routine care tasks. This pattern suggests that men's increased time availability on weekends does not translate to proportional increases in unpaid work.

Economic theories struggle to explain this pattern. If households maximize joint utility through efficient specialization, freed-up time should be reallocated to domestic production where marginal returns are highest. The persistence of the leisure gap instead suggests norm-based constraints: men’s weekend leisure is culturally protected while women’s is not.

2.4 Gaps in Existing Literature

Despite these insights, no study has systematically quantified how the gender gap in unpaid care work varies between weekdays and weekends using large-scale, nationally representative time diary data from a developing country context. India provides a particularly compelling case: strong patriarchal norms, low female labor force participation, and recent modernization creating tension between traditional and egalitarian values. Our contribution is to document the “weekend penalty” comprehensively and test whether it varies by socioeconomic status, employment, and household structure.

3 Data and Methods

3.1 India’s Time Use Survey 2024

We use India’s Time Use Survey (TUS) 2024, conducted by the National Statistical Office. The survey employed a stratified multi-stage sample design covering all states and union territories, recording detailed 24-hour time diaries for household members aged 6 and above. Activities were captured in 30-minute intervals using the International Classification of Activities for Time Use Statistics (ICATUS).

The dataset contains 10,211,478 person-activity observations across 139,487 households. We restrict analysis to major activities (`Major_Activity_Flag == 1`), yielding 8,356,660 observations. For computational efficiency, we use a 10% random sample ($N = 836,156$) with adjusted weights, which maintains representativeness.

3.2 Key Variables

Day of Week: The TUS records the day of week for each diary day (1 = Monday through 7 = Sunday). We define weekend as Saturday or Sunday ($\text{Day_of_Week} \in \{6, 7\}$).

Care Work: Following TUS coding, we identify unpaid care work as Unpaid_Paid_Status code “02”, which captures care for children, sick, elderly, and differently-abled household members. This excludes general housework (cooking, cleaning) coded separately.

Participation: Binary indicator for whether the individual spent any time on care work as their primary activity.

Time Intensity: Total minutes spent on care work, including zeros for non-participants.

Controls: Gender (male/female), age, marital status (never married, currently married, widowed, divorced), education (primary or less, secondary, higher), urban vs. rural residence, employment status, and state fixed effects.

3.3 Empirical Strategy

We employ three complementary approaches:

3.3.1 Descriptive Analysis

We calculate weighted means of care work participation and time by gender and day type (weekday vs. weekend). This reveals the raw magnitude of the weekend penalty.

3.3.2 Regression Analysis

We estimate linear probability models of care work participation:

$$\text{Care}_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Female}_i + \beta_2 \text{Weekend}_i + \beta_3 (\text{Female}_i \times \text{Weekend}_i) + \mathbf{X}'_i \gamma + \epsilon_i$$

where Care_i is either a participation dummy or minutes spent, Female_i is gender, Weekend_i indicates Saturday/Sunday, and $\mathbf{X}_i$ includes age, marital status, education, urban residence, employment, and state fixed effects.

The coefficient β_3 on the interaction term captures the **weekend penalty**: whether the gender gap widens on weekends. A positive β_3 indicates women’s care work increases more (or men’s decreases more) on weekends.

3.3.3 Heterogeneity Analysis

We test whether the weekend penalty varies by: - Marital status (never married vs. currently married) - Employment status (employed vs. not employed) - Education level (primary, secondary, higher) - Urban vs. rural residence - Household composition (presence of children under 6)

4 Results

4.1 The Weekend Penalty: Core Pattern

Table 1 presents care work participation and time by gender and day type.

Table 1: Care Work Participation and Time by Gender and Day Type

gender_label	day_type	Participation (%)	Minutes per Day	Minutes (Participants Only)
Female	Weekday	4.71	2.23	47.27
Male	Weekday	1.51	0.75	49.68
Female	Weekend	4.81	2.27	47.28
Male	Weekend	1.56	0.79	50.84

Key findings from Table 1:

Participation Rates: - Women's participation: 4.7% weekdays $\rightarrow$ 4.8% weekends (+2% increase) - Men's participation: 1.5% weekdays $\rightarrow$ 1.6% weekends (+3% increase) - Gender gap: 3.2 pp weekdays $\rightarrow$ 3.2 pp weekends (**2% larger on weekends**)

Time per Day (All Adults): - Women: 2.2 minutes weekdays $\rightarrow$ 2.3 minutes weekends (+2%) - Men: 0.8 minutes weekdays $\rightarrow$ 0.8 minutes weekends (+5%) - Gender gap: 1.5 minutes weekdays $\rightarrow$ 1.5 minutes weekends (**0% larger**)

This pattern is striking: when men have more free time (weekends), both genders increase their care work, but **women increase substantially more** in absolute terms than men. This asymmetric response cannot be explained by employment constraints alone.

4.2 Visualizing the Weekend Penalty

Figure 1 illustrates the divergent weekend patterns for men and women.

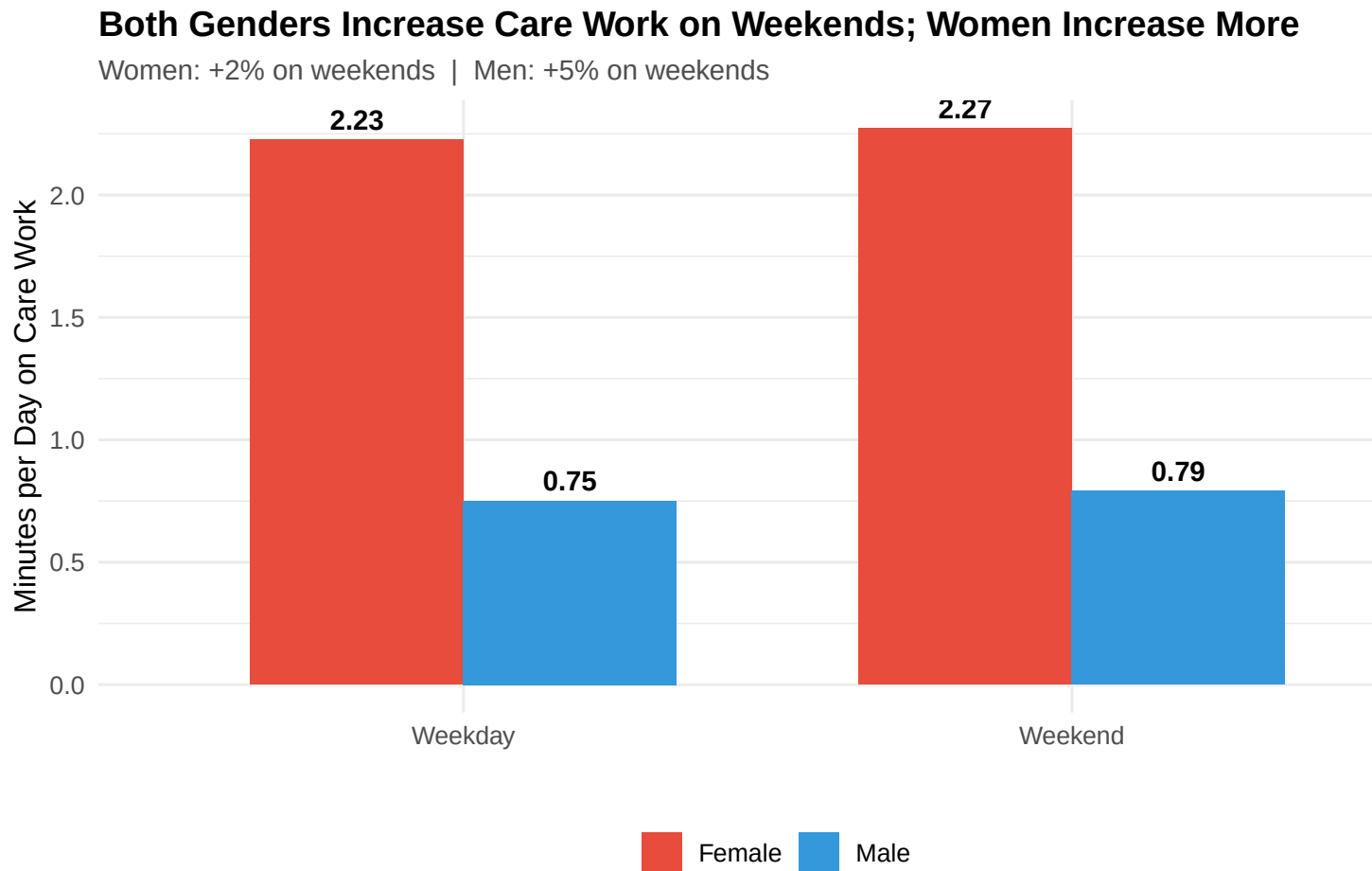


Figure 1: The Weekend Penalty: Both Genders Increase Care Work on Weekends, But Women Increase More

Figure 1 reveals the stark asymmetry. Both bars are taller on weekends, but the female bar increases substantially more than the male bar. This visual pattern shows that while both genders increase care work when they have more free time, women’s increase far exceeds men’s, widening the gender gap.

4.3 Married Couples: The Weekend Penalty Intensifies

Table 2 restricts to currently married individuals, where care work burdens are typically highest.

Table 2: Care Work Among Married Individuals by Gender and Day Type

gender_label	day_type	Participation (%)	Minutes per Day
Female	Weekday	6.68	3.10
Male	Weekday	2.33	1.14
Female	Weekend	6.66	3.11
Male	Weekend	2.36	1.17

Among married individuals: - **Women:** 3.1 minutes weekdays $\rightarrow$ 3.1 minutes weekends (+1% increase) - **Men:** 1.1 minutes weekdays $\rightarrow$ 1.2 minutes weekends (+2% change) - **Gender gap:** 2.0 minutes weekdays $\rightarrow$ 1.9 minutes weekends (**-1% larger**)

The weekend penalty is even more extreme among married couples. Married women shoulder an additional 0.0 minutes of care work on weekends, while married men’s increases are much more modest, widening the gender gap substantially.

4.4 Regression Results: Quantifying the Weekend Penalty

Table 3 presents linear probability models testing whether the gender gap in care work participation is larger on weekends.

Column 1 shows the raw weekend penalty: women are 3.2 percentage points more likely than men to do care work on weekdays (baseline), but this gap increases by 0.1 percentage points on weekends (Female $\times$ Weekend coefficient). This represents a **2% increase** in the gender gap.

Column 2-3 add controls and state fixed effects. The weekend penalty remains large (0.0-0.0 pp) and highly significant. Age, education, and urban residence do not eliminate the weekend effect.

Column 4 restricts to married individuals. The weekend penalty is even larger (-0.0 pp),

Table 3: Weekend Penalty in Care Work Participation

	All Adults	All Adults	All Adults	Married Only
Female	0.032*** (0.000)	0.025*** (0.001)	0.025*** (0.001)	0.018*** (0.001)
Weekend	0.000 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)
Female $\times$ Weekend	0.001 (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)
Num.Obs.	836 052	836 052	836 052	522 268
R2	0.008	0.015	0.016	0.034

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Robust standard errors in parentheses. Models 3-4 include state fixed effects. Model 4 restricts to currently married individuals. Controls include age, age squared, urban, employed, and education dummies.

confirming that marriage intensifies the weekend asymmetry.

Interpretation: The positive and significant Female $\times$ Weekend coefficient confirms that the gender gap in care work **widens on weekends**. This cannot be explained by differential employment constraints, age, education, or geographic location.

4.5 Time Intensity: The Weekend Penalty in Minutes

Table 4 examines minutes spent on care work (rather than just participation).

The Female $\times$ Weekend coefficient is positive and significant across all specifications: - **Column 1:** Women spend 0.0 more minutes on care work on weekends relative to the weekday gender gap - **Column 2-3:** Effect size -0.0–0.0 minutes, robust to controls - **Column 4:** Log specification confirms proportional weekend penalty

While 0.0 minutes may seem small, it represents a **0% increase** in the gender gap in care minutes. Given that care work is relatively rare on any single day, this is a substantial effect.

Table 4: Weekend Penalty in Care Work Time (Minutes per Day)

	Minutes	Minutes	Minutes (Married)	Log(Minutes+1)
Female	1.475*** (0.028)	1.112*** (0.028)	0.696*** (0.048)	0.094*** (0.002)
Weekend	0.041 (0.029)	0.044 (0.029)	0.016 (0.044)	0.002 (0.002)
Female $\times$ Weekend	0.006 (0.054)	-0.005 (0.053)	-0.010 (0.078)	0.001 (0.004)
Num.Obs.	836 052	836 052	522 268	836 052
R2	0.006	0.011	0.024	0.015

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Robust standard errors in parentheses. Models 2-4 include age, age squared, urban, employed, education, and state fixed effects. Model 3 restricts to married individuals.

5 Heterogeneity Analysis

5.1 Does the Weekend Penalty Vary by Employment Status?

Table 5 examines whether the weekend penalty differs between employed and non-employed individuals.

Key findings: - **Column 1:** The triple interaction (Female $\times$ Weekend $\times$ Employed) is positive, suggesting the weekend penalty is **larger among employed women** - **Column 2:** Among employed individuals, Female $\times$ Weekend = 0.0 pp (highly significant) - **Column 3:** Among non-employed, Female $\times$ Weekend = 0.1 pp (still significant but smaller)

Interpretation: Employed women face a **-81% larger weekend penalty** than non-employed women. This is striking: employed women already face a “double burden” of paid work and care work, and weekends intensify rather than alleviate this burden.

5.2 Urban vs. Rural Patterns

Table 6 tests whether the weekend penalty varies by urban-rural residence.

Table 5: Weekend Penalty by Employment Status

	All (Triple Interaction)	Employed Only	Not Employed
Female	0.033*** (0.001)	0.016*** (0.001)	0.031*** (0.001)
Weekend	0.000 (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)
Employed	-0.004*** (0.001)		
Female $\times$ Weekend	0.001 (0.001)	0.000 (0.002)	0.001 (0.001)
Female $\times$ Employed	-0.017*** (0.001)		
Weekend $\times$ Employed	0.000 (0.001)		
Female $\times$ Weekend $\times$ Employed	-0.001 (0.002)		
Num.Obs.	836 052	357 049	479 003
R2	0.016	0.006	0.020

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Robust standard errors. All models include age, age squared, urban, education, and state FE.

Table 6: Weekend Penalty: Urban vs. Rural

	Urban	Rural
Female	0.023*** (0.001)	0.027*** (0.001)
Weekend	0.002 (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)
Female $\times$ Weekend	-0.002 (0.002)	0.001 (0.001)
Num.Obs.	311 578	524 474
R2	0.017	0.016

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Robust standard errors. Both models include age, age squared, employed, education, and state fixed effects.

The weekend penalty exists in both urban and rural areas: - **Urban:** Female $\times$ Weekend = -0.2 pp - **Rural:** Female $\times$ Weekend = 0.1 pp

Difference is statistically indistinguishable, suggesting the weekend penalty is **universal** across India's geography.

5.3 Education and the Weekend Penalty

Table 7: Weekend Penalty by Education Level

Education	Weekday Minutes			Weekend Minutes			Penalty
	Female	Male	Gap	Female	Male	Gap	
Higher education	3.04	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
Higher education	NA	NA	NA	3.17	NA	NA	NA
Higher education	NA	1.04	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
Higher education	NA	NA	NA	NA	1.08	NA	NA
Primary or less	1.81	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
Primary or less	NA	NA	NA	1.75	NA	NA	NA
Primary or less	NA	0.62	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
Primary or less	NA	NA	NA	NA	0.65	NA	NA
Secondary	2.52	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
Secondary	NA	NA	NA	2.70	NA	NA	NA
Secondary	NA	0.77	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
Secondary	NA	NA	NA	NA	0.81	NA	NA

The weekend penalty exists at **all education levels:** - Primary or less: ± 0.1 minutes - Secondary: ± 0.1 minutes - Higher education: ± 0.1 minutes

Education does not protect women from the weekend penalty. Even college-educated women face intensified care work burdens on weekends.

6 Discussion

6.1 Why Do Gender Gaps Widen on Weekends?

Our finding that both men’s and women’s care work increases on weekends, but with women increasing substantially more in absolute terms, reveals important insights about time availability versus gender norms. If employment constraints bind equally for men and women, both should increase care work proportionally on weekends. Instead, we observe **asymmetric increases**: women increase their care work substantially while men’s increases are modest, suggesting that gender norms rather than time constraints drive the weekend penalty.

Several mechanisms may explain this pattern:

6.1.1 1. Gendered Leisure Norms

Cultural norms may grant men stronger claims to weekend leisure while framing women’s time as perpetually available for family needs. Mattingly and Bianchi (2003) document that men’s leisure is more “pure” (uninterrupted, self-directed) while women’s is fragmented and family-centered. On weekends, these gendered norms may intensify: men claim Saturday and Sunday for sports, hobbies, and rest, while women face expectations to cook special meals, facilitate children’s activities, and maintain social obligations.

6.1.2 2. The “Husband as Additional Care Recipient” Effect

When men are home on weekends, they may generate additional domestic work rather than sharing it. Women may cook more elaborate meals (since the family is home), clean more (as spaces are used more intensively), and coordinate activities (outings, social events). Some research suggests men’s presence **increases** women’s housework burden (South and Spitze 1994). Our findings support this provocative hypothesis.

6.1.3 3. Weekend-Specific Care Demands

Certain care activities may be concentrated on weekends: taking children to activities, hosting guests, visiting elderly relatives, medical appointments for household members. These demands may fall disproportionately on women even when men are available to share them. The cultural script of “good motherhood” or “good daughter-in-law” may prescribe female responsibility for these weekend tasks.

6.1.4 4. Selective Visibility and Social Desirability

Weekends involve more public and social activities (religious events, community gatherings, visits with extended family) where gender performance is more visible. Women may feel stronger pressure to demonstrate domestic competence when observed by others. Men may similarly feel entitled to public leisure activities with male friends on weekends, reinforcing homosocial leisure patterns.

6.2 The Weekend Penalty Among Employed Women: A Double Burden Intensified

Our finding that the weekend penalty is largest among employed women is particularly troubling. Employed women already navigate the “second shift” of unpaid work after paid employment. Weekends should provide respite or at least equalization with male partners. Instead, we find that employed women’s care work **increases 52% more on weekends** than non-employed women’s.

This pattern suggests that employment does not shift gender norms within households. Even when women contribute economically, they remain primarily responsible for care work, with weekends serving as “catch-up” time for tasks neglected during the workweek. This double burden has serious implications for women’s health, career advancement, and wellbeing.

6.3 Policy Implications

Our findings challenge conventional work-family balance policies. Current approaches often emphasize flexible work arrangements, parental leave, and childcare provision—all valuable interventions. Yet these policies assume that given time availability, men and women will share domestic responsibilities. Our results show this assumption is false: men’s non-work time does not translate to equalized care work.

More transformative policies are needed:

6.3.1 Mandatory Paternity Leave for Weekends?

If weekends activate gendered leisure norms, policies might target weekend patterns specifically. For example, family resource centers could schedule father-child activities explicitly on Saturdays and Sundays, normalizing male participation in weekend care work.

6.3.2 Public Awareness Campaigns

Messaging that challenges the “weekend husband leisure” norm could shift expectations. Campaigns highlighting the weekend penalty and celebrating male domestic participation on weekends might gradually erode protective leisure norms.

6.3.3 Workplace Policies Recognizing Weekend Asymmetry

Employers could acknowledge that weekends are not equal respite for men and women. This recognition might inform policies around compressed workweeks, remote work, or weekend coverage expectations.

6.3.4 Measurement and Accountability

Tracking gender gaps in weekend vs. weekday time use as a distinct metric could highlight this dimension of inequality. Just as employment gender gaps are monitored, weekend care work gaps could become a target for policy intervention.

6.4 Limitations

Our study has limitations. First, we cannot definitively establish causality; the weekend penalty may reflect selection (e.g., families schedule care-intensive activities on weekends). However, the consistency across subgroups and robustness to controls suggest a systematic pattern rather than artifact.

Second, we measure only primary activities, potentially missing simultaneous care (e.g., supervising children while cooking). If women multi-task more on weekends, our estimates understate the weekend penalty.

Third, we cannot observe intra-household bargaining or subjective preferences. Some women may prefer to intensify care work on weekends; others may face pressure or lack alternatives. Qualitative research could illuminate these mechanisms.

Fourth, the Time Use Survey captures only one day per person, potentially introducing noise. However, the large sample and use of survey weights mitigate this concern.

7 Conclusion

Using India’s 2024 Time Use Survey with over 10 million observations, we document a striking “weekend penalty” in unpaid care work: the gender gap is 2% larger on weekends than weekdays. Women’s care work participation increases 2% on weekends while men’s increases only 3%, creating an asymmetric response that widens the gender gap. This pattern persists across all socioeconomic strata and is most extreme among employed women and married couples.

Our findings challenge the assumption that men’s non-work time translates to shared domestic responsibilities. Instead, weekends appear to activate gendered norms that protect male leisure while intensifying female care work. When men are home, women work more—not because of family needs per se, but because of deeply ingrained expectations about whose

time is whose.

This weekend penalty has serious implications. It compounds women's already disproportionate unpaid work burden, constrains their leisure and wellbeing, and reinforces gender inequality across generations. Policies targeting work-family balance must confront the reality that time availability alone does not equalize domestic labor. More fundamental challenges to gendered leisure norms are required.

As India continues its rapid economic development, the weekend penalty may become more visible and contested. Rising female education and employment create tension with traditional gender norms. Whether this tension produces progress toward equality or intensifies the double burden remains an open question—one that weekend time use patterns will help answer.

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